Original Article

Policing the blank page movement: Insights from policing students, as a cohort of representatives of Generation Z

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Abstract Police decisions to arrest and disperse protestors, displaying anti monarch rhetoric during the funeral cortege of Queen Elizabeth ii, has questioned the right to freedom of expression under the Human Rights Act 1998. This presents a potential problem around public perception of police impartiality. This paper utilises an online questionnaire, with the aim of establishing views of youths aged 18 to 23 years old, as a sample of Generation Z, around police actions at the scene. It reviews whether restrictions towards freedom of speech, have negatively impacted upon perceptions of police impartiality. The hypothesis is that the participants will perceive freedom of speech as highly important, with restrictions to this right, damaging the concept of police impartiality. Findings highlight how participants acknowledge the importance of freedom of speech for democracy. However, there was doubt shown around whether police actions which appeared to restrict this right, impacted upon police impartiality.

Introduction

Previous studies have identified that within society there is a form of discrimination, which views youths less favourably than adults. This discrimination, often referred to as 'youngism', is said to be held by the media (Francioli and North, 2021, No page), as well as amongst older generations of 60 years plus, who stereotype youths as 'coddled, radically progressive, disrespectful, and inexperienced' (Van Vleck, 2021, no page). Yet youths offer a different analysis of society, where societal issues are understood, rather than condemned, a trait often attributed to adults. Youths are also positioned to challenge processes, otherwise taken for granted (Daiute and Fine, 2003). Therefore, in restricting voices of the youth, there is a dearth of understanding, shown towards matters which affect the young as they progress into adulthood (Boratav, 2005). Therefore, any discrimination towards youths will arguably restrict young adults in their exercise of 'social power' and student involvement within society (Martinez *et al.*, 2020, no page).

The relevance in understanding the views and opinions of youths, is currently prevalent amongst those born after the year 2000 and who have been afforded the label of *Generation Z* (Ozkan and Solmaz, 2015). This group of youths are said to be familiar with societal matters such as equality issues, as well as being proficient in the use of technology, which subsequently supports choices made (Talmon, 2019). Despite this, Schenarts (2020) highlights how

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Generation Z dislike risk and attempt to stay within comfortable boundaries. There is also an acute awareness shown by this group, around damage to personal reputation caused by the use of technology (Schenarts, 2020).

According to Schenarts (2020), older generations set the context for new generations. For example, perceptions of the police amongst previous generations, can be affected by experiences and displays of police fairness (Williams and Maxwell, 2022). Therefore, predecessor generations, such as the Baby Boomers, that is, those born after the Second World War (Kaifi *et al.*, 2012), Generation X, those born between 1965 and 1980 (Kaifi *et al.*, 2012), Generation Y, that is those born between 1982 and 2000 (McCrindle, 2003) and even Generation Z, have experienced, or witnessed footage of societal conflict, which will shape perceptions of the police (Williams and Maxwell, 2022). According to Flory (2000), Generation X maintain a distrust for authority in favour of a more democratic approach (Flory, 2000). Whilst, Generation Y or *Millennials,* are underwhelmed by authority, due to a familiarity with supervision experienced whilst growing up (Sledge, 2016). This cohort, require guidance with life direction (McCrindle, 2003), but as 'digital natives', are shaped by the existence and ability to communicate, via the internet (Milkman, 2017, p. 2).

When comparing differences between older generations and Generation Z, Seemiller and Grace (2018), highlight how previous groups have tolerated societal differences but Generation Z, have advocated for more inclusivity, rejecting discrimination and oppression and focussing more towards a rights based society. Generation Z therefore represents the 'most disruptive generation the world has ever seen', as this group of youths are not complacent around societal problems but instead, are keen to find resolutions around such matters (Sengupta, 2020, p. 8). In studying this cohort, there will be a better understanding of Generation Z around matters of 'power, deference and legitimacy' (McCargo, 2021, p. 1) and also around issues, which are both important to society and which impact upon the lives of so many (Giray, 2022).

The study reviewed policing students perceptions, as a sample of Generation Z, around the concept of freedom of speech entrenched within the Human Rights Act 1998 and whether there is the perception that police actions, that is, of arrest and the moving on of anti-monarch protestors, negatively impacted upon police impartiality. The findings highlighted how Generation Z, identify police powers as important in dealing with protestors but have shown doubt around whether the police were right to move on, or arrest demonstrators. The participants were also unsure whether police actions would impact upon public perceptions of police impartiality. The results also highlight, how policing students, as a sample of Generation Z view freedom of speech and the right to protest, as more important than the maintenance of law and order.

Discretion, trust and legitimacy as a form of resolution

According to Stott *et al.* (2008), the strategy to arrest protestors, can potentially arise from the negative preconceptions held by the police towards crowds. This is based upon the idea that crowds have the potential for violence. This theory is both relevant and concerning, when it is acknowledged how police decisions made via the use of police discretion, will be informed through a use of stereotypes (Ullrich, 2020). These stereotypes highlight the existence of bias, which can impact upon police actions (Worden *et al.*, 2020). However, the police are still subject to impartiality, which requires officers to work without any form of discrimination, shown towards any one group (College of Policing, 2023). The police are therefore required to treat all individuals with fairness and respect, without which, the police will be unable to secure the required respect within public and police co-operation (Jackson *et al.*, 2012b).

For Stott *et al.* (2008), there is a need for the police to engage protestors, via a non-confrontational strategy. Any use of force by the police, must therefore be actioned upon intelligence, as well as the police having a clear plan which will potentially assist in defusing incidents of conflict. In any attempt to defuse a confrontation, it is therefore essential that both protesters and the police, view each other as legitimate bodies which will reduce the likelihood of disorder at protests (Waddington,

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1987). For Jackson *et al.* (2012a), this legitimacy between police and protestor, will be dependent upon the parties formation of trust. It could therefore be argued that in building this trust, a strategy is required which implements diffusion of conflict, rather than a strategy of arrest. Furthermore, police decisions must be morally right (Joyce and Laverick, 2021). This will subsequently overrule any strict application of the law. Therefore, despite the need for the police to react quickly during protests, there should not be an over reliance, upon the guidance issued by police forces on the subject matter. Instead, Tummers and Bekkers (2014) highlight the importance of discretion over strict adherence to policy, as policies do not always cover the matter being addressed and secondly through discretion, the policy can be adapted, so that it is more appropriate to the circumstance. In contrast, over reliance on force guidance, according to the House of Commons Home Affairs Committee (2011), will be detrimental to both common sense and police powers of discretion. Despite this stance, police officers at the Queen's funeral, were issued with guidance by the National Police Chiefs Council (NPCC) on how to manage protestor's rights and the public's right to grieve. This guidance has not been made accessible to the public (BBC News, 2022b). However, the NPCC, stated that each incident of protest, was to be individually assessed, with the concept of impartiality, being adhered to (INews, 2022).

The concept of police discretion has been identified as a beneficial tool within the policing world and aligns with matters such as having 'freedom of judgment and action; having the ability to decide and choose and the ability to select the best course of action, having recognised and considered all alternatives' (Rogers and Lewis, 2007, p. 71). According to Nowacki (2015), the significance of discretion is its ability to assist the police with Asinterpretation of unclear laws, whilst also assisting officers in dealing with minor breaches of the law. However, discretion can also have a detrimental impact where officers have the opportunity, to enter the realm of misconduct. In addition, the use of discretion has led to the under and over policing of certain groups (Poyser, 2004); where there is the propensity for young males, the poor and even working classes, being subject to the more negative aspects of police action (Box, 1999). Yet according to Monaghan (2021, p. 47), discretion remains important, as it allows the police to move away from arrests and instead, towards a culture of crime prevention and problem solving. Discretion will therefore provide the police with the freedom to make decisions where appropriate and in a manner, which does not require strict stringent enforcement of the law (Smith, 2021). The beneficial nature of discretion was particularly relevant following the introduction of the Human Rights Act 1998, where the police were required through the use of discretion to use less punitive measures in dealing with protestors, who decided to exercise freedom of expression and where disorder was anticipated (Channing, 2015). According to Gorringe and Rosie (2008, p. 189), police discretion was arguably more available, when there was a form of 'negotiated management' with protestors, which existed through a strategy of police discussions and co-operation. As part of this strategy, the police protect the right to protest, whilst enduring the disruption that the protests will cause. The alternative of which, would involve the suppression of protestors and consequently increase the propensity for violence, which can be detrimental to the police image. The death of civilian Ian Tomlinson, who died after being pushed to the ground by a Metropolitan Police Officer during the G20 summit, highlights the scrutiny the police can find themselves under, when dealing with protests. Such incidents will undoubtedly place the police under significant pressure to respond to protestors both correctly and effectively, whilst also ensuring a strategy of non-complacency, which has been the subject of much criticism, by the House of Commons Home Affairs Committee (2011).

Police, humans rights and conflicting legislation

According to Stott *et al.* (2008), there is a need to consider alternative ways in dealing with conflict, which have been established through results uncovered by evidence-based strategies. This can ultimately diffuse situations of conflict and assist in the reduction of subsequent breaches to rights of freedom, currently permitted within society and which are enshrined within the basis of fundamental

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human rights. As an example, legislation such as the right to freedom of expression as presented under Article 10 of the Human Rights Act 1998 (Gov. UK, 1998) provides individuals with a fundamental right to express 'opinion, conviction and belief', within any democratic society (Gunatilleke, 2021, p. 1). However, the concept of freedom of expression as contained within the 1998 Act, is not an absolute right. This means that individuals reliant on Article 10 of the 1998 Act, are still potentially liable for arrest by the police (Rogers and Lewis, 2007), when risks are connected to national security; morals; public health; public order and also when the respect for the reputation and rights of another are at threat (Howie, 2018).

The fragility of the 1998 Act, has consequently been highlighted by Hopkins Burke (2004), who highlighted how the rights of individuals established under the Human Rights Act 1998, are both fragile and non-absolute and therefore vulnerable to breaches by public authorities including the police. The arrest of members of the public by the Metropolitan Police in 2022, during a vigil for murder victim Sarah Everard provided evidence of this potential for breaches to the Act to occur. Although the vigil was compounded by the fact that it took place during the COVID Pandemic when restrictions of movement were in place, it was still alleged that the Metropolitan Police Constabulary had failed to allow protestors the right to freedom of expression and freedom of assembly. Despite this claim, the Metropolitan Police were later exonerated by the force watchdog however, the force was later found guilty at High Court, of failing to preserve the rights of the protestors, around matters connected to freedom of assembly and freedom of expression. According to Lord Justice Warby, the Metropolitan Police despite its legal duty had failed to review the reasoning held by the protestors, in holding the vigil (BBC News, 2022c).

According to the HMIC (2011), the problem for the police is that protests can take place unexpectedly and can place the police under significant pressure. As a result, the police need to adapt quickly to circumstances, which cannot always be planned for (HMIC, 2011). Recently the Conservative Government has provided the police with additional powers to use against protestors, through the introduction of new legislation such as the Police, Crime and Sentencing Court Act 2022 (Gov. UK, 2022). Under this new legislation the police can take action where demonstrations are deemed to be too noisy and which subsequently, amount to disruption to an organisation or cause significant impact to those in the area (Gov. UK, 2022). The use of such legislation combined with existing laws such as Breach of the Peace and the Public Order Act, provide the police with significant powers to react to protestors. This has the potential to consequently impact negatively upon perceptions of police legitimacy (Channing, 2021), as well as providing issues around an individual's willingness to abide by the law (Li *et al.*, 2021).

The danger for the police in its use of the Police, Crime and Sentencing Court Act 2022, is that it has arguably led to significant reform of protestors rights. This subsequently restricts rights to freedom of expression and freedom of assembly, long established under the Human Rights Act 1998. Such restriction around established rights, as identified through the enforcement of emergency laws restricting public freedom of movement during the COVID Pandemic, highlights the danger of policing in England and Wales becoming 'a police state' (Hickman *et al.*, 2020, no page). According to Hickman *et al.* (2020) the police during the COVID Pandemic, went beyond what was established as law, in order to enforce the interests of the government. As a result, the non-clarity surrounding police application of laws such as the Police, Crime and Sentencing Court Act 2022, may lead the police to interpret and enforce the law, in favour of the interests of the government. Martin (2021) highlights, how even during its introduction, the Police, Crime and Sentencing Court Bill proved to be controversial, raising questions around the power of the legislation to restrict protestor's rights when views presented, contrasted with government perspectives.

Currently, policing in England and Wales aligns with the concept of democratic policing. Although difficult to define, the term democratic policing is consistent with matters which deal with 'consensus' and 'freedom and equality '(Rogers, 2013, p. 135). The effectiveness of this current style of policing, will be dependent upon the public's common consent to be governed by the police (Rogers and Coliandris, 2015). Norrie and Singh (2022, p. 10)

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argue that this is based upon the principle that the police 'do not bother the public, any more than necessary'. Furthermore, Reiner (1985) highlights how the concept of policing by consent, was built upon matters which included, the police being free from political interference and on the premise that minimal force would be used in prevention of disorder. As a result, the police would not be viewed as oppressors but instead would be viewed as an impartial entity, who enforce law and order. The significance of this, is that without public consent, trust and confidence in the police, as well as failings in identifying the police as a legitimate body, will make the task of policing arduous and affect the desired co-operation, required within police and public relations (Torrible, 2022). As a result, the police are required to treat individuals fairly, creating a relationship of trust, which in turn 'generates institutional legitimacy' (Jackson *et al.*, 2012, p. 5). The concept of legitimacy and its impact for policing, is that it can assist in achieving public co-operation; compliance with police instruction and achieve public satisfaction (Mazerolle *et al.*, 2013). This process allows the police to work effectively within their role, whilst also allowing for the establishment and monitoring of societal norms around public behaviour (Sunshine and Tyler, 2003). In order to police effectively, it is therefore imperative that the police have the co-operation of the public, in order to provide an effective role. This will be evidenced through the public's voluntary co-operation with the police, rather than the through a system which relies upon fear of force, all of which will assist compliance with the police (Farrow, 2022). However according to Bonner (2020, no page), there is a difficulty in establishing how the police connect to perceptions of a democratic society, when there are issues surrounding democracy and perceptions of the police, as enforcers of the state. As a result, 'how best to balance this tension, depends upon political ideology'. According to Gerber and Jackson (2017, p. 80), political ideology is 'a varied set of shared beliefs about the appropriate order of society and the accepted means to achieve this order'. Therefore, when assessing political ideology, factors such as an allegiance to a political party cause, can assist in facilitating public perceptions of police fairness (Roché and Roux, 2017).

According to Tyler (2004), In order to gain the voluntary support and co-operation of the public, the police must be viewed as legitimate body. Only then will the public view the police as an entity of authority, who the public will obey. The amount of trust existing between the public and police, is of paramount importance to the police. This has resulted with the police making concerted efforts to move away from perceptions of more military styles of policing strategies, often connected to protests of the 1970s and 1980s era (Jackson *et al.*, 2019). For senior police officers, the need for reform within the policing of protests, was based upon the need for increased consideration around protestors human rights (HMIC, 2011). However, this approach to placing human rights at the forefront of strategies connected to policing protests, has been questioned by Schwarz (2019), who argues how both the police and new laws which aim to prevent protests, are tools of the government and are to be viewed as reinforcement of societal control. This links to Bonner's (2020) earlier theory, with regards to issues of democracy and the role of the police as enforcers of the state. Therefore, any use of force by the police during such protests, will negatively impact upon public perceptions of trust towards the police and consequently affect the concept of police impartiality (Nagel and Nivette, 2022). This arguably will be at the detriment of the hard work and gains established within public and police relations and which has been achieved through an ability by the police, to problem solve and implement community policing (O'Reilly, 2021). As a result, it is important for the police to maintain a strategy of effective policing around protests, whilst also ensuring positive engagement within the community (Gorringe *et al.*, 2012).

The importance of police impartiality has been acknowledged by the College of Policing (2023a), within its publication of the Police Code of Ethics, which establishes the standards of professional police behaviour (College of Policing, 2023b). According to the College of Policing (2023b), police impartiality aligns with concepts such as fairness and objectivity, which require the police to act in a manner which is non-discriminatory against any one group, and which subsequently ensures the rights of individuals, to equally speak out. However,

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according to Reiner (2010), this is difficult to achieve, as the police role itself may be identified as discriminatory in nature, as there is always someone who will be subject to policing. This was highlighted in 2022, during the funeral procession of Queen Elizabeth II, where anti-monarch protestors were arrested and moved on by the police, following attempts to protest against the new monarch King Charles III (BBC News, 2022a). The event also saw a further protestor being questioned by the police, around the intended content proposed to be written, upon a blank piece of paper. Here the police were perceived by the protestors as participating in the withdrawal of the human right to freedom of expression, culminating in protestors next displaying blank paper, in defiance of police actions (BBC News, 2022a).

Competing values and police impartiality

Protests witnessed at the Queen's funeral cortege, could arguably be attributed to the presence of what appears to be two competing cultural values, prominent within the crowd. These competing values are liberalism and conservatism. According to Akkus *et al.* (2020, p. 50), the differences which exist between liberalism and conservatism, can lead to 'intra societal conflict', where the concept of liberalism—which aligns with matters of 'universalism, benevolence and self-direction', directly conflicts with conservatism values, which include; 'security, power, achievement, tradition and conformity'. Therefore, it could be argued that the police, during the Queen's funeral, have been caught in the middle of a complex situation of competing values between protestors and the general public. The protestors appeared to embrace a more liberalism stance to the governance of the monarchy, whilst the surrounding crowds have embraced a more conservatist based approach to such governance. The two competing value systems, subsequently highlight the complexity for the police role, in the maintenance of an equilibrium in 'competing rights and needs' (HMIC, 2011, p. 3). This is also combined with an additional complexity, where perceptions of the police as holders of power, are expected to align with values of the community. However, as De Graf *et al.* (2016) highlight, this is a difficult task to achieve and one which will inevitably lead to the making of choices. The making of such choices may require action to be taken by the police, which is not an easy task, as police behaviour can subsequently impact upon public attitudes and furthermore, impact upon perceptions of the police (Skoggan, 1996). Despite this, it is vital for the police to be representatives of an impartial agency within the maintenance of order within society, as this will have the advantage of creating restraint, amongst protestors (Waddington, 1987). However, according to Bonner and Dammert (2022), the concept of police impartiality is questionable, because despite the police being viewed as impartial enforcers of the law, the police are rarely free of political bias and unfortunately, the police will resort to confrontations from previous protests and use stereotypical views, in order to inform any decisions made when relying upon police discretion (Ullrich, 2020).

Methodology

Research design

The empirical research was designed to capture university policing student's thoughts and feelings on the policing of protestors at the Queen's funeral cortege, where anti-monarch protestors had been subject to arrest and been moved on from the area. As university students, the participants represented a small cohort of Generation Z, that is, a group of students born after the year 2000 and who were asked to answer the following questions. Firstly, how important is freedom of speech and secondly, did police actions towards anti-monarch protestors at the Queen's funeral cortege, damage the concept of police impartiality?

The research commenced with the circulation of an online questionnaire, created using a Microsoft Office application. Microsoft Office was selected due to the efficiency and effective way of collecting data (Peters, 2018). The data was collated, utilising a triangulation approach, which refers to a strategy of using two or more data collection methods within research (Bryman, 2004). In this instance both qualitative and quantitative research methods were utilised. Qualitative data was utilised, as this

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method 'aims to explore diversity rather than to quantify; emphasises description and narration of feelings, perceptions and experiences, rather than their measurement' (Kumar, 2014: 379) Whilst in contrast quantitative research had the benefit of being based 'on the measurement of quantity or amount' (Kothari, 2004, p. 3). Within this current study, quantitative data would assist in measuring the number of students attached to a particular response, whilst qualitative data, would assist in the collation of student thoughts and feelings around the subject matter. The triangulation design of data collection, would facilitate a better understanding around the similarity and contrasting points of the topic being researched and in addition, provide a complete overview of the subject which may have been lost, if focus was given to a single data collection method (Ostland *et al.*, 2011).

Sample size and technique

The current study was circulated amongst 278 university students based upon all 4 years of a policing course, ranging from the Foundation Year through to Year 3. The students formed part of a convenience sample, as the researcher had ease of access to the participants, due to the researcher's role of lecturer at the university. Furthermore, as the students were taken from a policing course, there was an ability to understand both police terminology used within the study, along with general matters and issues connected to policing, taught within the Policing Degree. This was an important factor in this study, as there was also a curiosity, as to whether all research responses, would be indicative of a pro-police response, or whether exposure to curriculum content, which includes a review of human rights and high-profile cases, would lead to an alternative response, away from pro-police views. Therefore, the participant characteristics, as well as the age range of the sample, meant that this cohort also formed part of a purposive sample. According to Andrade (2020, no page), a purposive sample is 'one whose characteristics are defined for a purpose that is relevant to the study'.

Despite a request for participants from the course at all levels of undergraduate study, only 57 out of 278 students, volunteered to complete the questionnaire. This was a small sample size, in comparison to the total number of students enrolled upon the course. As a result, there was an acknowledgement that there could not be a generalisation of results (Tracy, 2013). However, according to Tracy (2013), quality rather than quantity of data is often identified as more relevant, especially with regards to qualitative research.

Data collection methods

The participants of the study were contacted via an advert requesting participants, which was placed upon the university's internal email system, along with a link to the Microsoft questionnaire. The email highlighted that the research was voluntary, with no pressure on participants to complete it. According to Habib *et al.* (2014), when creating a questionnaire, there are several important considerations. These include the structure of the questionnaire; types of questions asked and how these would be phrased. Such considerations were pertinent to the collection of data, within the current study. However, according to Caulfield and Hill (2014), even with a carefully constructed questionnaire, if your sample is not appropriate to your study, the data collated will be of little value. In the current study the sample was deemed as appropriate, as it offered an insight into the minds of students, who aspire to become future police officers.

Ethical considerations

According to Caulfield and Hill (2014), prior to commencing research, consideration must be provided around the protection of participants. As a result, when contacting the students via the general email system located within the university internal site, it was clearly explained to the participants that the research was voluntary and also anonymous. The concept of anonymity would therefore assist in protecting participant confidentiality. Furthermore, through the provision of the informed consent form, participants were given comprehensive detail around the research, before deciding whether or not, to provide their consent to take part (Robson and McCartan, 2016). According to Hope and McMillan (2004, no page), researchers must ensure that 'the

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enthusiasm of the researcher, does not override the interests of the individual participants'. However, despite the existence of the informed consent form, Varnhagen *et al.* (2005) argue, that participants are failing to read this information or attributing little attention to its detail. This theory had a bearing on the construction of questions used within the questionnaire. For example, the specific design of questions, was centred around providing detail to the participants on what specifically the police actions were, in order to assist as a reminder to the sample, of what was being questioned. It was also felt necessary, for this reason, to construct questions with a focus on the type of protestors being discussed, that is, anti- monarch protestors.

Data analysis

Transparency within the analysis of data and in the utility of research methods, is vital in order to provide an evaluation into the trustworthiness of data (Nowell *et al.*, 2017). In the current study, quantitative data was analysed within the Microsoft Forms application, through an 'in built data analytics' process. This data was automatically transferred by the application into graphs, whilst also allowing qualitative data, to be downloaded onto an Excel Spreadsheet (Microsoft Support, 2023, no page). The use of qualitative data provided support towards the credibility of responses, which could not have been achieved by relying on one source alone' (Robson and McCartan, 2015).

Limitations of the research

It was acknowledged that the participants of the study, as students of a policing course, may represent a biased sample. However, the sample still represents a small cohort of Generation Z participants. As such, this study presented a unique analysis into understanding the thought processes of those, eventually seeking employment as police officers. Understanding these perspectives is arguably important, as such perspectives could potentially influence future policing decisions. Therefore, there is a need to fill a dearth of knowledge around youth perceptions, particularly from this cohort, as the group enters adulthood. A point addressed earlier by Boratav (2005).

Unfortunately, the response rate for the questionnaire was low. According to Clark *et al.* (2021), low response rates are normal within academic research. It was also noted upon reflection, that the questionnaire design could have been more aesthetically pleasing, with the use of visual aids, rather than through the use of text alone. Visual aid usage been found to positively impact upon the willingness of students to complete an online questionnaire (Deutskens *et al.*, 2004). Therefore, the study could have incorporated the use of Likert Scales to aid participant completion (South *et al.*, 2022), whilst providing an effective method, of evaluating perspectives (Dourado *et al.*, 2021).

Question design is vital, in attempts to avoid leading participants towards a required response, which would consequently create a form of bias. However, it is also acknowledged, that bias will exist in most research publications (Pannucci and Wilkins, 2010). In the current research, protestors were categorised as *anti-monarch*, which may potentially facilitate a form of bias in responses provided. However, the approach taken, was utilised as a form of clarification and focus for the sample, as to the category of protestor being reviewed, because research has identified, the potential for participants to provide little attention to the information sheet, detailing the research (Varnhagen *et al.*, 2005).

Discussion

The online questionnaire commenced, by asking the 57 participants, how important police powers were, when dealing with protestors (Fig. 1).

Twenty five of the participants, argued that police powers were extremely important, whilst only one participant, argued that police powers were not important at all. The views of the majority therefore appear to highlight the credibility and value, that Generation Z have placed in the powers afforded to the police. This in turn would imply, that the participants have trust in the police to use such powers as an effective tool. This highlights how Generation Z perceive the police as a legitimate body. This perception of the police as a legitimate body, will ensure voluntary co-operation between the public and the police (Tyler, 2004).

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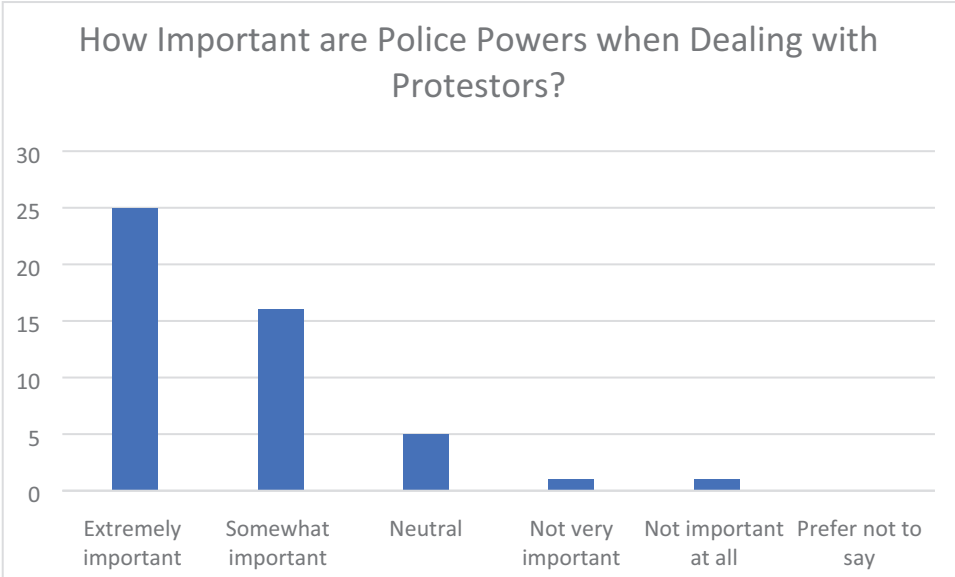

Figure 1: Protestors and the Importance of Police Powers

The participants were then asked whether individuals should have the right to freedom of speech as provided under Article 10 of the Human Rights Act 1998 (Fig. 2).

Thirty five of the participants stated 'yes', which supports the perspective provided by HMIC (2009), who highlighted the importance for the police, in acknowledging human rights as part of any policing strategies, utilised during protests. However, it is also interesting to note how twelve of the participants, viewed this right to be dependent upon the circumstances, which appears to highlight an awareness by the participants, of the notable exceptions to freedom of speech, found under the 1998 Human Rights Act. These exceptions, are taught as part of the Policing Degree curriculum, produced by the College of Policing and may highlight the participants knowledge and understanding, around the Acts limitations to freedom of speech, which connect to matters of national security; morals; public health; public order and respect for the reputation and rights of another (Howie, 2017).

The participants were next asked, whether the moving on/arrest of anti-monarch protestors by the police, was justified (Fig. 3).

The results to this question were mixed, with 16 participants selecting 'yes' and nineteen students being 'unsure'. Only seven participants, argued that the police were wrong in their actions. For one participant, the importance of impartiality was acknowledged:

> Answering as a staunch monarchist, and disagreeing fundamentally with the protest, freedom of speech should always be protected, even if one does not agree with what is being said, otherwise police impartiality may be jeopardised.

This comment supports the theory presented earlier by Nagel and Nivette (2022), who identified how any use of force by the police, towards protestors, can negatively impact upon the public perception of trust shown towards the police and subsequently impact upon perceptions of police impartiality.

Another area of the empirical research, reviewed whether the arrest and moving on of protestors by the police, can be perceived as impacting upon the public's view of police impartiality (Fig. 4).

This question received a mixed response with a majority of 15 participants answering that they were

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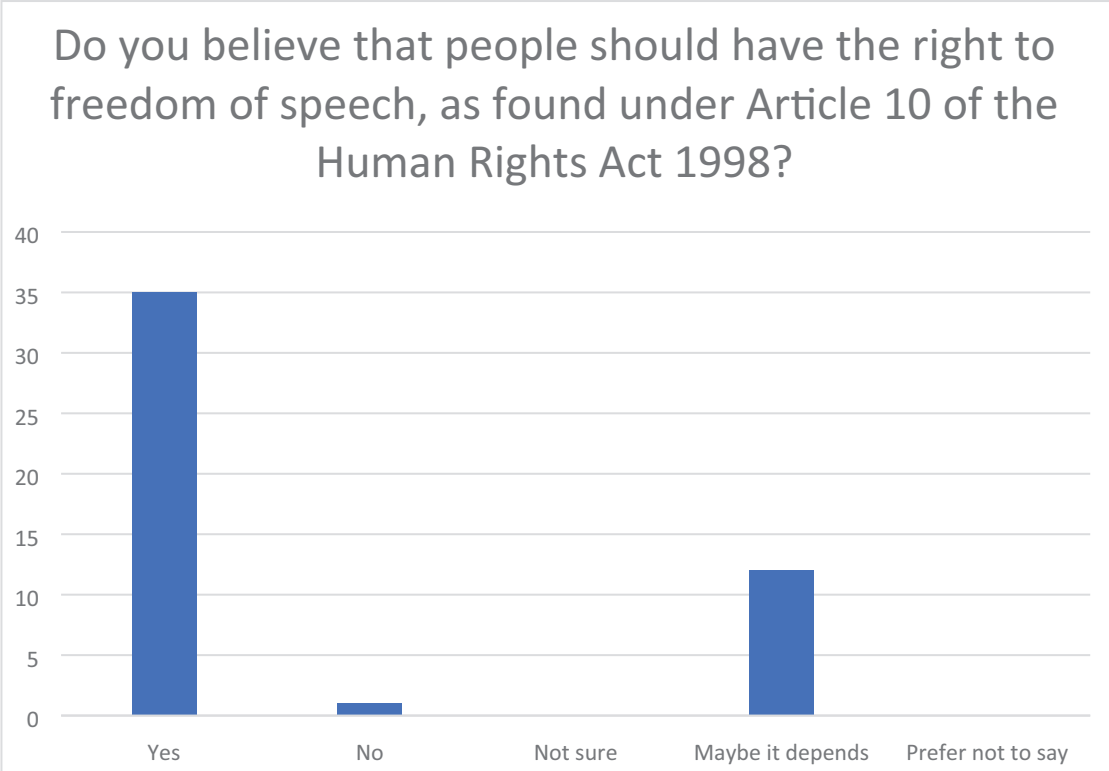

Figure 2: The Right to Freedom of Speech

'not sure', whilst 14 participants stated that police actions 'may be' perceived as impacting upon public views of police impartiality. The lowest response was from six participants, who answered that these police actions, would not be seen as impacting upon police impartiality. As part of this question, the participants were asked to expand upon the answer provided and it was clear that one of the main reoccurring themes, was the importance of neutrality within policing. One participant for example commented:

> The police must maintain a neutral stance on all protests and should never take sides in protests, rallies or parades as they represent the whole of the country and the individuals that it comprises of all of whom who have differing opinions.

The relevance of police impartiality was also identified, when participants were asked about who the police should concentrate upon, during protests involving anti-monarch rhetoric (Fig. 5).

The results identified that 33 participants required both groups, that is, protestors and members of public to be equally concentrated upon during protests. This suggests that Generation Z have the ability to acknowledge the significance of impartiality, equality and fairness within policing, as established within the Police Code of Ethics, which sets the standards for professionalism within the police.

The benefit of concepts such as impartiality, was also significant for Waddington (1987), who highlighted how impartiality, reduces the need for conflict between the police and protestors, where it facilitates restraint amongst protestors.

The participants were finally asked to select the option, which was perceived as most important, within the list provided (see Table 6) (Fig. 6).

The majority of participants, that is, 24 participants, when presented with the options selected 'It

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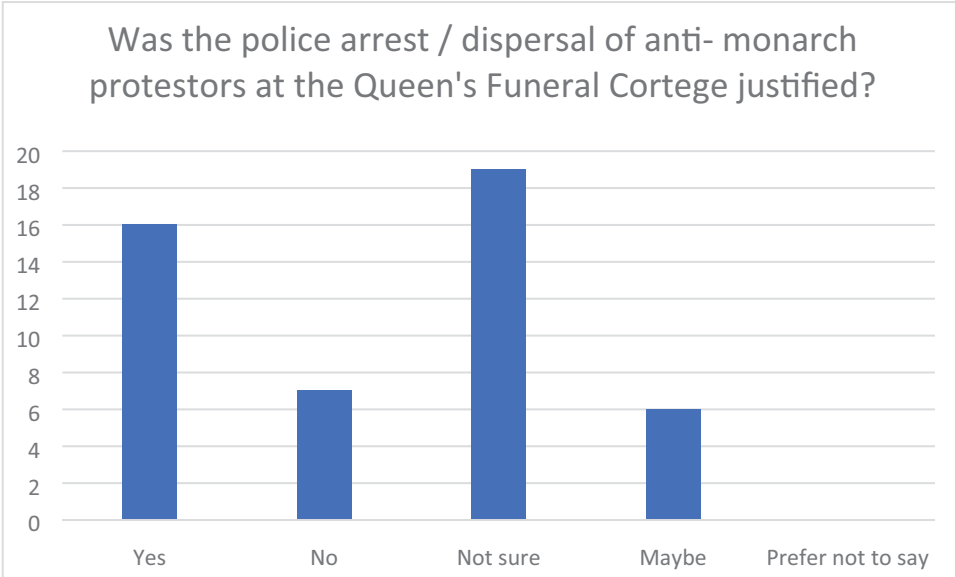

Figure 3: Perceptions on Whether Police Actions were Justified

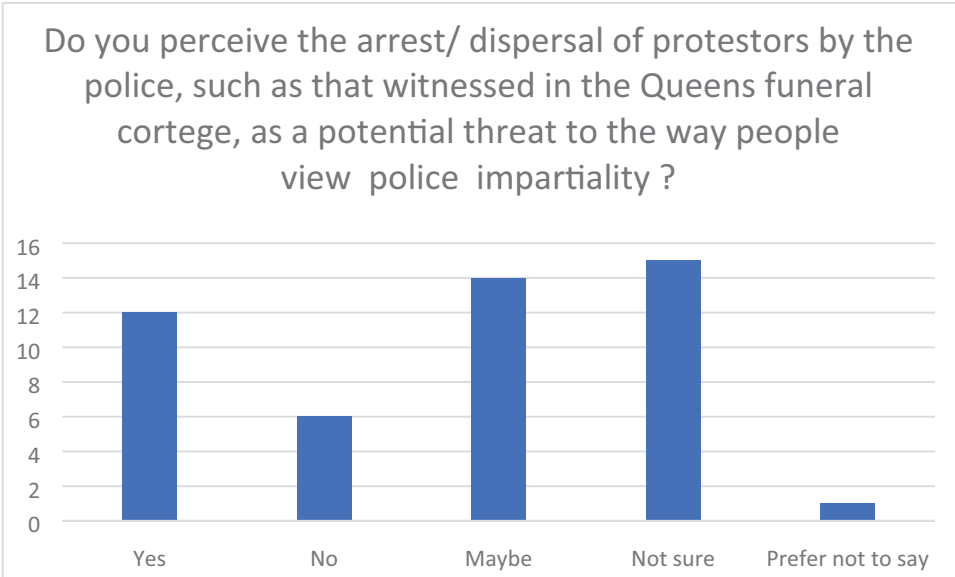

Figure 4: Police Actions and the Impact upon Impartiality

depends on the circumstance'. Only five participants, selected 'maintenance of law and order'. However it was also noted, that 11 of the participants saw the right to protest and the exercise freedom of speech, as more important than maintenance of law and order. For some participants, freedom of speech was closely associated to the concept of democracy, with one participant commenting:

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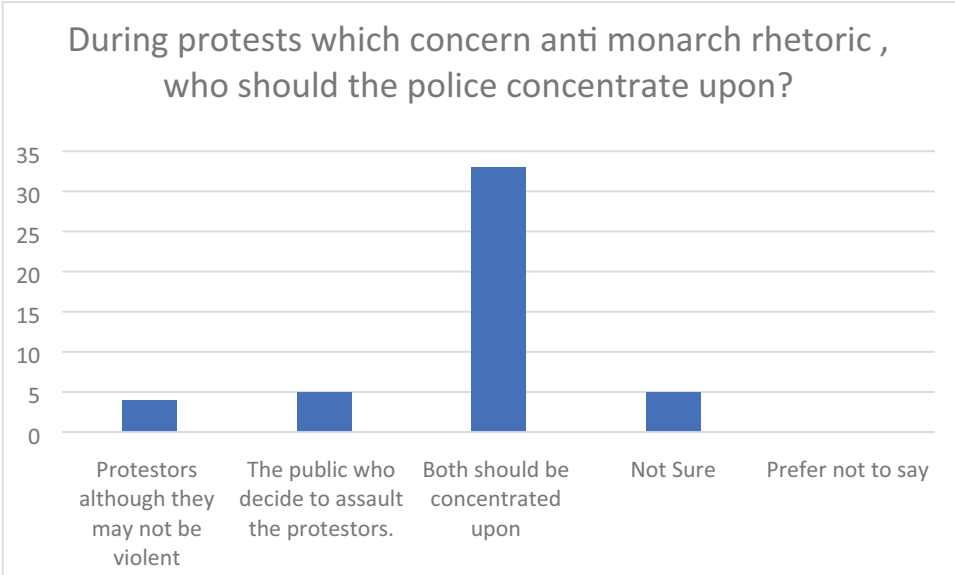

Figure 5: Focus of Police Actions During the Protest

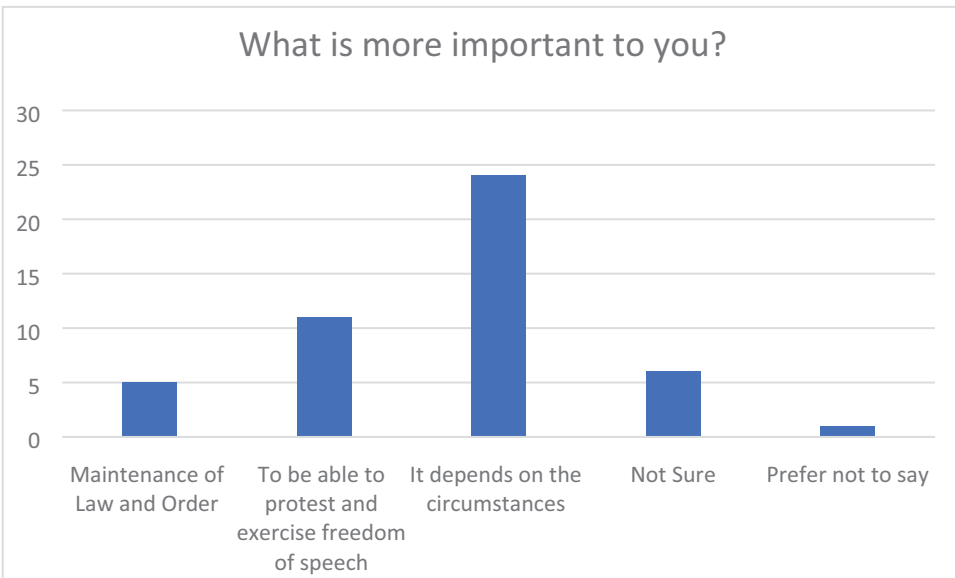

Figure 6: Matters of Importance for Participants, During the Protest

While law and order are important, the ability to speak out for a fundamental change must remain a freedom of the people, else we drift further away from a democracy.

This comment also appears to support the work of Hickman *et al.* (2020), who acknowledge how restriction of rights, can be associated with a police state, as opposed to a system of democratic policing, on which Western Society currently depends.

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Conclusion

The right to freedom of speech found under Article 10 of the Human Rights Act 1998 provides the public with a fundamental right to voice an opinion or belief. Although not an absolute right, it provides a fundamental right, which is entrenched within a democratic society. However, the moving on and arrest of protestors, about to and in the process of expressing anti-monarch rhetoric, at the Queens funeral cortege has led to scrutiny and questions, surrounding police actions towards protestors at this event.

Policing of protests has recently been compounded by the introduction of laws such as The Police, Crime and Sentencing Court Act 2022, which has negatively impacted upon the rights of individuals to exercise the right to freedom of speech, as found under Article Ten of the Human Rights Act 1998. However, as enforcers of the law, the police maintain a difficult role, in demonstration of police impartiality, fairness and equality as found within the Police Code of Ethics. As a result, police actions will remain under close scrutiny. Any doubt afforded to the concept of police impartiality, will be identified as damaging for a democratic model of policing and instead portray the police, as oppressors and akin to an authoritarian police state.

As a generation born after 2000, the views of Generation Z towards freedom of speech and police impartiality are significant, in that they provide a greater and deeper understanding of perceptions of youths, around these matters. The current research highlighted that Generation Z, appear to be aware of the importance of freedom of speech in a democratic society. As a result, the police must try its best to maintain the right to freedom of speech, where none of the limitations, found under the Human Rights Act 1998 apply. Consideration must be afforded to confrontations being dealt with via a form of negotiated management first, with arrests utilised as a last resort. As a result, the police must be encouraged and supported to utilise discretion and evidence-based strategies, in consideration of alternative strategies in dealing with conflict.

Participants in the current study, remain unsure whether police actions towards protestors, impacted upon police impartiality. The reluctance to provide a definitive yes or no, could be indicative of a trait connected to Generation Z, whereby this cohort realise the potential for reputational damage, caused through the use of technology. This is a potential concern for this group, who seek a career within policing. The participants however, appeared less reluctant to hold back, when acknowledging the importance of freedom of speech, over maintenance of law and order. As a result, it is vital that the police work to uphold neutrality within policing of protestors. The relevance of this for the police, is that without the maintenance of impartiality, the police will fail to be viewed as a legitimate body, which will have implications for the policing role and make co-operation with the public, a more arduous task. The police must be in a position to continue to respect the rights of individuals enshrined within the Human Rights Act, as this is the only way to ensure any form of future co-operation, between police and protestor.

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